NEW YORK STATE | Office of Information Technology Services

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New York State Information Technology Guideline	No: ITS-G26-002
IT Guideline: **Lake Ontario Map Label Retention**	**Updated:** 10/16/2026
	Issued By: NYS Office of Information Technology Services **Owner:** Chief Digital Office

1.0 Purpose and Benefits

On August 27, 2026, U.S. Executive Order 14422 was issued directing U.S. Federal agencies to rename the geographic feature known as “Lake Ontario” as “Lake America.” Subsequently, Lake Ontario’s name was changed in the Geographic Names Information System (GNIS) which is the official Federal source for geographic names and used in Esri basemaps. As a result, all maps and applications generated after August 27, 2026 from ArcGIS Online (AGOL), as well as any applications that are using Esri’s basemaps, and any map applications using Google Maps could reflect this change.

New York State agencies have been directed by Governor Hochul to continue using “Lake Ontario.” To ensure consistency, compliance, and control over how maps display this label, please review and implement the guidance in this document.

2.0 Authority

Section 103(10) of the State Technology Law provides the Office of Information Technology Services (ITS) with the authority to establish statewide technology policies, including technology and security standards. *Section 2 of Executive Order No. 117*[1], issued January 2002, provides the State Chief Information Officer

[1] All references to Executive Order 117 refer to that which was originally issued by Governor George E. Pataki on January 28, 2002 and continued by Executive Order 5 issued by Governor Eliot Spitzer on January 1, 2007, Executive Order 9 issued by Governor David A. Patterson on June 18, 2008, Executive

with the authority to oversee, direct and coordinate the establishment of information technology policies, protocols and standards for State government, including hardware, software, security and business re-engineering. Details regarding this authority can be found in NYS ITS Policy, *NYS-P08-002 Authority to Establish State Enterprise Information Technology (IT) Policy, Standards and Guidelines*.

3.0 Scope

This guideline applies to ITS, its employees, contractors, and consultants and ITS supported agencies ("Client Agency").

This guideline applies to Client Agency designated Esri AGOL administrators as well as application developers using Esri basemaps or Google Maps.

4.0 Information Statement

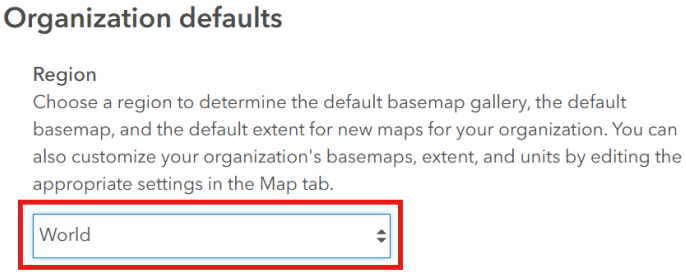
The following explains the steps ITS and its Client Agencies need to adjust AGOL sites, AGOL maps and applications, custom applications using Esri basemaps, and Google Map instances.

4.1 Actions for AGOL Administrators

4.1.1 Change Regional Settings

To prevent unintended label changes on default basemaps, administrators should adjust the AGOL organization's regional settings from *United States* to *World*. This ensures that default basemaps for new maps and applications will continue to display "Lake Ontario" where appropriate. To adjust these regional settings, please follow the steps outlined below:

1. Log into the AGOL site as an administrator.
2. Select the **Organization** > **Settings** > **General**.
3. Under Organization defaults, change the Region to World (the setting saves automatically).



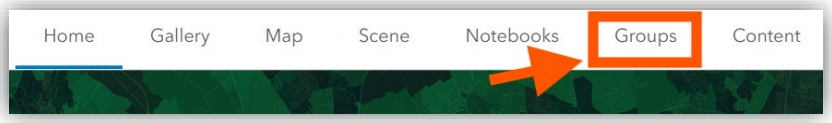
Order 2 issued by Governor Andrew M. Cuomo on January 1, 2011 and Executive Order 6 issued by Governor Kathy Hochul on October 8, 2021.

Once these regional settings are applied, users will see the correct world basemap within the AGOL map or application. Please note that if an anonymous user changes the basemap using the basemap gallery tool, the gallery will display options based on their physical location, which may result in the “Lake America” label being shown when a different base map is selected.

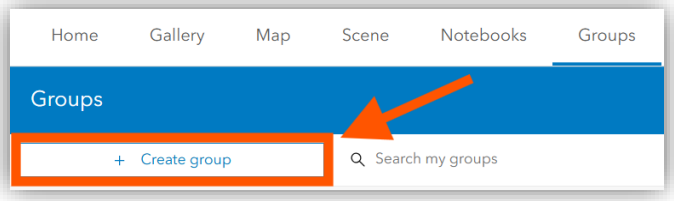
To eliminate this issue, administrators can set a custom basemap gallery as the default and then allow anonymous access to the organization. (Learn more about anonymous access from guidance available here).

4.1.2 Create Default Basemap Gallery that uses “World” Editions of Esri Basemaps

1. Log in to the AGOL site as an administrator.
2. From the homepage, click the “Groups” tab in the top toolbar.



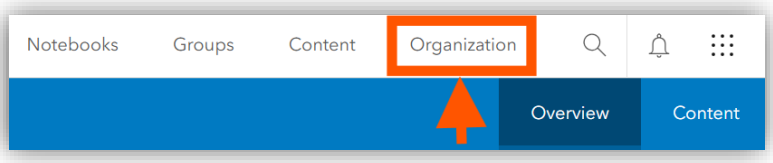
3. Click the [+ Create Group] button (top left).



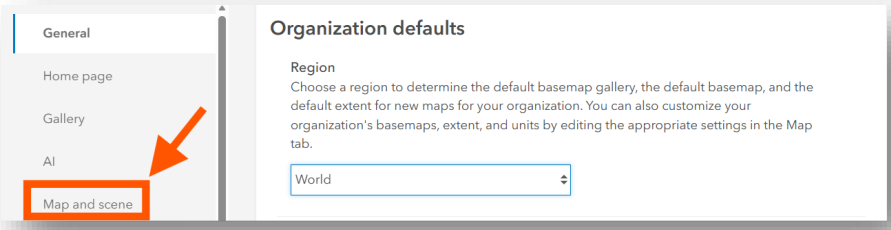
4. Use the following text and settings for the new group:

   Name: Basemap Gallery
   Summary: Organizational basemaps using Esri “World” basemaps
   Tags: Basemaps
   Thumbnail: Optional, upload an image for bonus points
   Who can view this group? Everyone (public)
   Who can be in this group? My organization’s members only
   How can people join this group? By invitation
   Who can contribute content? Group owner and managers
   Who can see the full list of members? Group owner and managers
   Group designations: Leave both options disabled

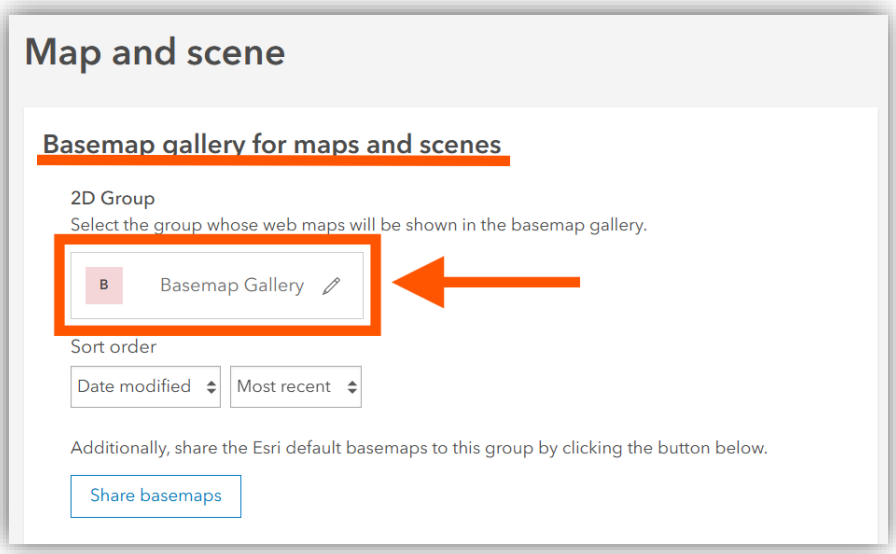
5. Click the blue “Save” button to finish creating the Group.
6. Next, click the “Organization” tab in the top toolbar.



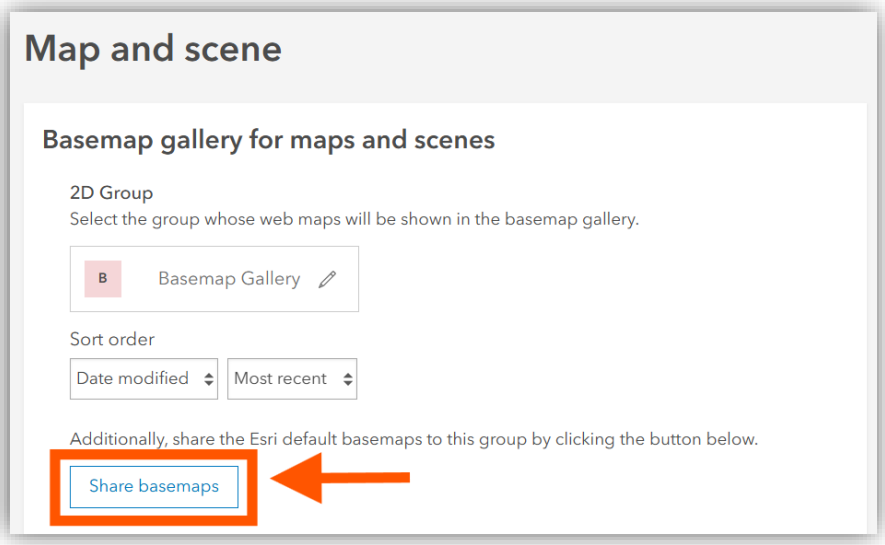
7. Then in the blue toolbar, click “Settings” (to the far right).
8. In the lefthand navigation bar, click “Map and Scene.”



9. Under the “Basemap gallery for maps and scenes” section, click on the box under “2D Group” (with the pencil icon) and choose the new “Basemap Gallery” group that you just made.

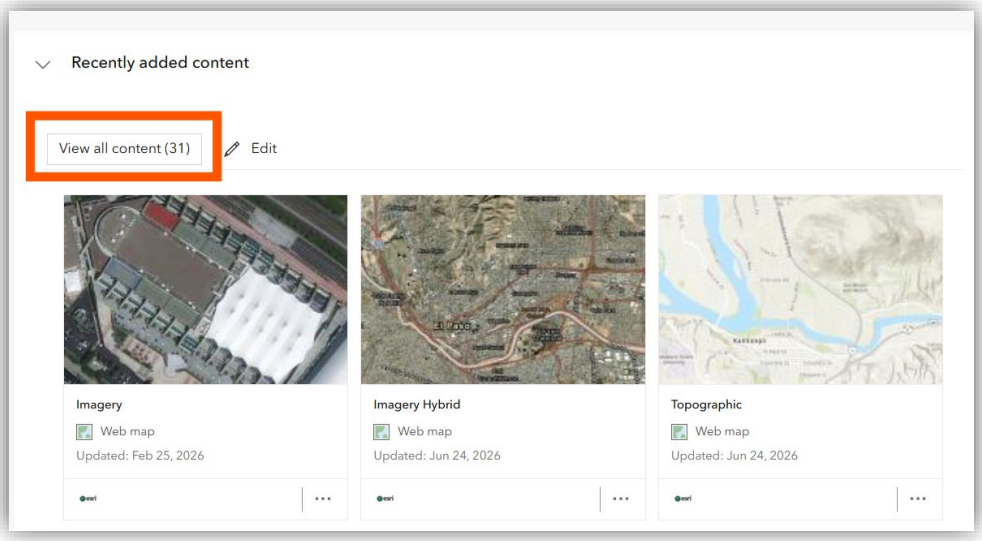


10. Once you set the Basemap Gallery group as the default, click the blue button below it that says “Share basemaps.” This will add all the default Esri Basemaps (World editions) into your group.



11. Navigate back to your Basemap Gallery group (Click Groups at the top toolbar, then choose the Group from the list).

12. On the Basemap Gallery group item page, make sure your content now includes Esri World Basemaps.



4.1.3 Allow for Anonymous Access to AGOL

1. Log into the AGOL site as an administrator.
2. Go to **Organization > Settings > Security**.
3. Under the **Access and Permissions** section, toggle on the option to "Allow" anonymous access to your organization's website.

Combined, the steps outlined in sections 4.1.1-4.1.3 result in the basemaps showing "Lake Ontario" instead of "Lake America" being publicly available.

4.1.4 Customize your AGOL Homepage

Once anonymous access is enabled, any public user will be able to see the organization's homepage and view content that is public. The homepage can be customized to eliminate sections that are either not relevant to or should be hidden from anonymous users. To do this, please follow the steps outlined below:

1. Go to **Organization > Settings > General**.
2. Scroll down the options in General until you reach the **Navigation Bar** section.
3. Click the button to **Manage Navigation Bar Links**.
4. In the window that opens, change the selection for any options set to "**Everyone**" to instead be "**Organization members**" or "**Organization members who can create."**

4.2 Actions for AGOL Map and Application Owners

4.2.1 Update Maps Applications with your AGOL Organization's Basemap Gallery

Once the AGOL administrator has completed the changes described above, agency owners of public AGOL maps and applications should check them to confirm the changes have taken effect. If maps are showing "Lake America" instead of "Lake Ontario," the steps below should be followed. Once completed, maps should be periodically reviewed to ensure continued use of "Lake Ontario."

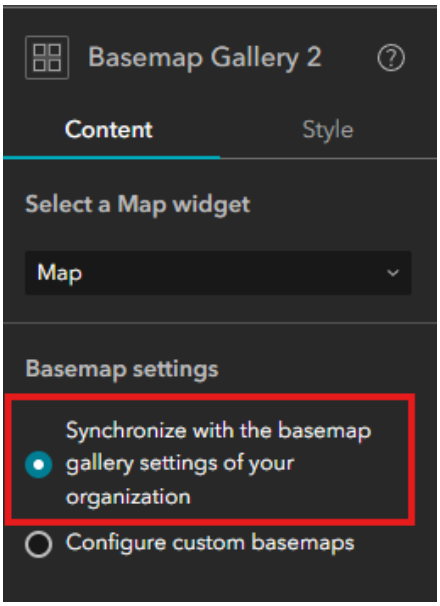
Maps

1. Open the map's **Overview** page in AGOL.
2. Locate and note the current basemap in the Map section of the Overview page.
3. Select **Open in Map Viewer**.
4. Open the **Basemap** tool on the left.

5. Select the desired basemap (e.g., a custom style or a "World" regional basemap) and **Save** the map to begin using the selected basemap.

Applications

When setting up widget-based applications like Experience Builder, ensure that the basemap widget is configured to use your organization's default basemap gallery. This will ensure the basemap widget displays the World basemap collection addressed in steps 4.1.1 and 4.1.2. This setting can be found in the map widgets settings.



4.3 Actions for Custom Application Developers

To avoid viewing the recent GNIS name change for Lake Ontario, developers should refrain from using the Basemap Gallery element. Instead, configure applications to use either the World Vector Basemaps or the Raster Legacy Basemaps which are not affected by the GNIS name change.

Note: Raster legacy basemaps are set to retire in 2028/2029

4.4 Google Maps Language Setting for Lake Ontario

To keep the internationally recognized name, "Lake Ontario," review any embedded Google Map on your websites and set the Maps language parameter to "en-CA (Canadian English)." If a map already sets "language=en" or "language=en-US," replace it with "en-CA." The map will stay in English but will

show “Lake Ontario” instead of “Lake America.” After deploying, open the live page, zoom to the Great Lakes and confirm that the lake is labeled "Lake Ontario."

4.5 Code examples

Script tag

```
<script
src="https://maps.googleapis.com/maps/api/js?key=YOUR_KEY&callback=initMap&language=en-CA"></script>
```

@googlemaps/js-api-loader

```
new Loader({ apiKey: "YOUR_KEY", version: "weekly", language: "en-CA" });
```

Embed iframe

```
<iframe
src="https://www.google.com/maps/embed/v1/place?key=YOUR_KEY&q=Lake+Ontario&language=en-CA"></iframe>
```

5.0 Compliance

This guideline shall take effect upon publication. Compliance with ITS guidelines is not compulsory, but strongly suggested. ITS may amend its guidelines at any time; compliance with amended guidelines is not compulsory, but strongly suggested.

6.0 Definitions of Key Terms

Except for terms defined in this policy, all terms shall have the meanings found in the ITS Glossary.

7.0 Contact Information

Submit all inquiries and requests for future enhancements to the policy owner at:

Chief Digital Office
Reference: ITS-G26-002
NYS Office of Information Technology Services
State Capitol, ESP, P.O. Box 2062
Albany, NY 12220-0062

Email: its.dl.cdo-all@ny.gov

Statewide technology policies, standards, and guidelines may be found on the Policies page of the ITS website.

8.0 Revision History

This guideline should be reviewed consistent with the requirements set forth in ITS-P24-003 Process for Establishing Information Technology Policies, Standards, and Guidelines.

Date	Description of Change	Reviewer
10/16/2026	Issued policy	Chief Digital Office

9.0 Related Documents